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Identifying duplicate data based on recently read data

Abstract

Deduplicating data based on recently reading the data, including: determining whether a calculated signature for write data matches a particular signature corresponding to data that was recently read from the storage device, wherein the signature is calculated using the write data as input; and after determining that the calculated signature for the write data matches the particular signature, obtaining the data that was recently read and comparing the data that was recently read to the write data.

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Background/Summary

CROSS REFERENCE TO RELATED APPLICATIONS

(1) This is a continuation application for patent entitled to a filing date and claiming the benefit of earlier-filed U.S. Pat. No. 11,921,633, issued Mar. 5, 2024, herein incorporated by reference in its entirety, which is a continuation of U.S. Pat. No. 11,360,682, issued Jun. 14, 2022, which is a continuation of U.S. Pat. No. 10,761,759, issued Sep. 1, 2020, which is a continuation of U.S. Pat. No. 9,594,678, issued Mar. 14, 2017.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF DRAWINGS

- (1) FIG. 1 sets forth a block diagram of an example system configured for preventing duplicate entries of identical data in a storage device according to embodiments of the present invention.
- (2) FIG. 2 sets forth a block diagram of an example storage array controller useful in preventing duplicate entries of identical data in a storage device according to embodiments of the present invention.
- (3) FIG. 3 sets forth a flow chart illustrating an example method for preventing duplicate entries of identical data in a storage device according to embodiments of the present invention.
- (4) FIG. 4 sets forth a flow chart illustrating an additional example method for preventing duplicate entries of identical data in a storage device according to embodiments of the present invention.
- (5) FIG. 5 sets forth a flow chart illustrating an additional example method for preventing duplicate entries of identical data in a storage device according to embodiments of the present invention.
- (6) FIG. 6 sets forth a flow chart illustrating an additional example method for preventing duplicate entries of identical data in a storage device according to embodiments of the present invention.

DESCRIPTION OF EMBODIMENTS

(7) Example methods, apparatuses, and products for preventing duplicate entries of identical data in a storage device in accordance with the present invention are described with reference to the accompanying drawings, beginning with FIG. 1. FIG. 1 sets forth a block diagram of a system configured for preventing duplicate entries of identical data in a storage device according to embodiments of the present invention. The system of FIG. 1 includes a number of computing

devices (**164, 166, 168, 170**). Such computing devices may be implemented in a number of different ways. For example, a computing device may be a server in a data center, a workstation, a personal computer, a notebook, or the like.

(8) The computing devices (**164, 166, 168, 170**) in the example of FIG. **1** are coupled for data communications to a number of storage arrays (**102, 104**) through a storage area network ('SAN') (**158**) as well as a local area network (**160**) ('LAN'). The SAN (**158**) may be implemented with a variety of data communications fabrics, devices, and protocols. Example fabrics for such a SAN (**158**) may include Fibre Channel, Ethernet, Infiniband, Serial Attached Small Computer System Interface ('SAS'), and the like. Example data communications protocols for use in such a SAN (**158**) may include Advanced Technology Attachment ('ATA'), Fibre Channel Protocol, SCSI, iSCSI, HyperSCSI, and others. Readers of skill in the art will recognize that a SAN is just one among many possible data communications couplings which may be implemented between a computing device (**164, 166, 168, 170**) and a storage array (**102, 104**). For example, the storage devices (**146, 150**) within the storage arrays (**102, 104**) may also be coupled to the computing devices (**164, 166, 168, 170**) as network attached storage ('NAS') or object services capable of facilitating file-level or "object" access, or even using SAN-NAS and/or object hybrids that offer file-level, object, and/or block-level protocols from the same systems or to the same storage server. Any other such data communications coupling is well within the scope of embodiments of the present invention.

(9) The local area network (**160**) of FIG. **1** may also be implemented with a variety of fabrics and protocols. Examples of such fabrics include Ethernet (802.3), wireless (802.11), and the like. Examples of such data communications protocols include Transmission Control Protocol ('TCP'), User Datagram Protocol ('UDP'), Internet Protocol ('IP'), HyperText Transfer Protocol ('HTTP'), Wireless Access Protocol ('WAP'), Handheld Device Transport Protocol ('HDTP'), Session Initiation Protocol ('SIP'), Real Time Protocol ('RTP') and others as will occur to those of skill in the art.

(10) The example storage arrays (**102, 104**) of FIG. **1** provide persistent data storage for the computing devices (**164, 166, 168, 170**). Each storage array (**102, 104**) depicted in FIG. **1** includes a storage array controller (**106, 112**). Each storage array controller (**106, 112**) may be embodied as a module of automated computing machinery comprising computer hardware, computer software, or a combination of computer hardware and software. The storage array controllers (**106, 112**) may be configured to carry out various storage-related tasks. Such tasks may include writing data received from the one or more of the computing devices (**164, 166, 168, 170**) to storage, erasing data from storage, retrieving data from storage to provide the data to one or more of the computing devices (**164, 166, 168, 170**), monitoring and reporting of disk utilization and performance, performing RAID (Redundant Array of Independent Drives) or RAID-like data redundancy operations, compressing data, encrypting data, and so on.

(11) Each storage array controller (**106, 112**) may be implemented in a variety of ways, including as a Field Programmable Gate Array ('FPGA'), a Programmable Logic Chip ('PLC'), an Application Specific Integrated Circuit ('ASIC'), or computing device that includes discrete components such as a central processing unit, computer memory, and various adapters. Each storage array controller (**106, 112**) may include, for example, a data communications adapter configured to support communications via the SAN (**158**) and the LAN (**160**). Although only one of the storage array controllers (**112**) in the example of FIG. **1** is depicted as being coupled to the LAN (**160**) for data communications, readers will appreciate that both storage array controllers (**106, 112**) may be independently coupled to the LAN (**160**). Each storage array controller (**106, 112**) may also include, for example, an I/O controller or the like that couples the storage array controller (**106, 112**) for data communications, through a midplane (**114**), to a number of storage devices (**146, 150**), and a number of non-volatile Random Access Memory ('NVRAM') devices (**148, 152**).

(12) Each NVRAM device (**148, 152**) may be configured to receive, from the storage array controller (**106, 112**), data to be stored in the storage devices (**146**). Such data may originate from any one of the computing devices (**164, 166, 168, 170**). In the example of FIG. 1, writing data to the NVRAM device (**148, 152**) may be carried out more quickly than writing data to the storage device (**146, 150**). The storage array controller (**106, 112**) may be configured to effectively utilize the NVRAM devices (**148, 152**) as a quickly accessible buffer for data destined to be written to storage. In this way, the latency of write requests may be significantly improved relative to a system in which the storage array controller writes data directly to the storage devices (**146, 150**).

(13) A 'storage device' as the term is used in this specification refers to any device configured to record data persistently. The term 'persistently' as used here refers to a device's ability to maintain recorded data after loss of a power source. Examples of storage devices may include mechanical, spinning hard disk drives, Solid-state drives (e.g., "Flash drives"), and the like.

(14) The storage array controllers (**106, 112**) of FIG. 1 may be configured for preventing duplicate entries of identical data in a storage device according to embodiments of the present invention. The storage array controllers (**106, 112**) may prevent duplicate entries of identical data in a storage device by receiving a write request to write data to the storage device; calculating one or more signatures for the data associated with the write request; determining whether any of the calculated signatures match a calculated signature contained in a recently read signature buffer, each entry in the recently read signature buffer associating a calculated signature for data that has been read with an address of a storage location within the storage device where the data is stored; and responsive to determining that one of the calculated signatures matches a calculated signature contained in the recently read signature buffer, determining whether the data associated with the calculated signature is a duplicate of data stored at a particular address that is associated with the calculated signature contained in the recently read signature buffer, as will be described in greater detail below.

(15) The arrangement of computing devices, storage arrays, networks, and other devices making up the example system illustrated in FIG. 1 are for explanation, not for limitation. Systems useful according to various embodiments of the present invention may include different configurations of servers, routers, switches, computing devices, and network architectures, not shown in FIG. 1, as will occur to those of skill in the art.

(16) Preventing duplicate entries of identical data in a storage device in accordance with embodiments of the present invention is generally implemented with computers. In the system of FIG. 1, for example, all the computing devices (**164, 166, 168, 170**) and storage controllers (**106, 112**) may be implemented to some extent at least as computers. For further explanation, therefore, FIG. 2 sets forth a block diagram of a storage array controller (**202**) useful for preventing duplicate entries of identical data in a storage device according to embodiments of the present invention.

(17) The storage array controller (**202**) of FIG. 2 is similar to the storage array controllers depicted in FIG. 1, as the storage array controller (**202**) of FIG. 2 is communicatively coupled, via a midplane (**206**), to one or more storage devices (**212**) and to one or more NVRAM devices (**214**) that are included as part of a storage array (**216**). The storage array controller (**202**) may be coupled to the midplane (**206**) via one or more data communications links (**204**) and the midplane (**206**) may be coupled to the storage devices (**212**) and the NVRAM devices (**214**) via one or more data communications links (**208, 210**). The data communications links (**204, 208, 210**) of FIG. 2 may be embodied, for example, as Peripheral Component Interconnect Express ('PCIe') bus.

(18) The storage array controller (**202**) of FIG. 2 includes at least one computer processor (**232**) or 'CPU' as well as random access memory ('RAM') (**236**). The computer processor (**232**) may be connected to the RAM (**236**) via a data communications link (**230**), which may be embodied as a high speed memory bus such as a Double-Data Rate 4 ('DDR4') bus.

(19) Stored in RAM (**214**) is an operating system (**246**). Examples of operating systems useful in storage array controllers (**202**) configured for preventing duplicate entries of identical data in a

storage device according to embodiments of the present invention include UNIX™, Linux™, Microsoft Windows™, and others as will occur to those of skill in the art. Also stored in RAM (236) is an array management module (248), a module that includes computer program instructions for preventing duplicate entries of identical data in a storage device according to embodiments of the present invention. The functionality of the array management module (248) will be described in greater detail below, but readers will appreciate that while the array management module (248) and the operating system (246) in the example of FIG. 2 are shown in RAM (168), many components of such software may also be stored in non-volatile memory such as, for example, on a disk drive, on a solid-state drive, and so on.

(20) The storage array controller (202) of FIG. 2 also includes a plurality of host bus adapters (218, 220, 222) that are coupled to the processor (232) via a data communications link (224, 226, 228). Each host bus adapter (218, 220, 222) may be embodied as a module of computer hardware that connects the host system (i.e., the storage array controller) to other network and storage devices. Each of the host bus adapters (218, 220, 222) of FIG. 2 may be embodied, for example, as a Fibre Channel adapter that enables the storage array controller (202) to connect to a SAN, as an Ethernet adapter that enables the storage array controller (202) to connect to a LAN, and so on. Each of the host bus adapters (218, 220, 222) may be coupled to the computer processor (232) via a data communications link (224, 226, 228) such as, for example, a PCIe bus.

(21) The storage array controller (202) of FIG. 2 also includes a host bus adapter (240) that is coupled to an expander (242). The expander (242) depicted in FIG. 2 may be embodied as a module of computer hardware utilized to attach a host system to a larger number of storage devices than would be possible without the expander (242). The expander (242) depicted in FIG. 2 may be embodied, for example, as a SAS expander utilized to enable the host bus adapter (240) to attach to storage devices in an embodiment where the host bus adapter (240) is embodied as a SAS controller.

(22) The storage array controller (202) of FIG. 2 also includes a switch (244) that is coupled to the computer processor (232) via a data communications link (238). The switch (244) of FIG. 2 may be embodied as a computer hardware device that can create multiple endpoints out of a single endpoint, thereby enabling multiple devices to share what was initially a single endpoint. The switch (244) of FIG. 2 may be embodied, for example, as a PCIe switch that is coupled to a PCIe bus (238) and presents multiple PCIe connection points to the midplane (206).

(23) The storage array controller (202) of FIG. 2 also includes a data communications link (234) for coupling the storage array controller (202) to other storage array controllers. Such a data communications link (234) may be embodied, for example, as a QuickPath Interconnect ('QPI') interconnect.

(24) Readers will recognize that these components, protocols, adapters, and architectures are for illustration only, not limitation. Such a storage array controller may be implemented in a variety of different ways, each of which is well within the scope of the present invention.

(25) For further explanation, FIG. 3 sets forth a flow chart illustrating an example method for preventing duplicate entries of identical data in a storage device (360, 362, 364) according to embodiments of the present invention. The storage devices (360, 362, 364) depicted in FIG. 3 may be embodied, for example, as SSDs that are included in an array of storage devices, depicted in FIG. 3 as a storage device array (358).

(26) The example method depicted in FIG. 3 is carried out, at least in part, by a deduplication module (310). The deduplication module (310) depicted in FIG. 3 may be embodied, for example, as a module of computer program instructions executing on computer hardware such as a computer processor. The deduplication module (310) depicted in FIG. 3 may reside in memory that is contained in a storage array controller that is similar to the storage array controller described above with reference to FIG. 2.

(27) The example method depicted in FIG. 3 includes receiving (312) a write request (306) to write

data (308) to one or more of the storage devices (360, 362, 364) in an array (358) of storage devices. The write request (306) of FIG. 3 may be embodied, for example, as one or more messages received by a storage array controller that is executing the deduplication module (310). The one or more messages may include, for example, a first message to initiate the write process and one or more subsequent messages that include the data, all of which may be received by the storage array controller over a data communications network such as a SAN, a LAN, or any other data communications link. The write request (306) of FIG. 3 may include, for example, an identification of a device, file, object, other service to which the write request (306) is issued, an identification of a user or server that issued the write request (306), the data (308) that is to be written to the one or more of the storage devices (360, 362, 364), a reference to the data (308) that is to be written to the one or more of the storage devices (360, 362, 364), and any other information needed to service the write request (306).

(28) The example method depicted in FIG. 3 also includes calculating (314) one or more signatures (316) for the data (308) associated with the write request (306). The one or more signatures (316) for the data (308) associated with the write request (306) represent identifiers of the data (308) that can be used to distinguish dissimilar data. Such a signature (316) may be embodied, for example, as a numeric value generated by applying a predetermined hash function to the data (308).

Calculating (314) one or more signatures (316) for the data (308) associated with the write request (306) may therefore be carried out by applying one or more predetermined hash functions to the data (308) associated with the write request (306). That is, calculating (314) one or more signatures (316) for the data (308) associated with the write request (306) may be carried out by utilizing the data (308) as input to one or more predetermined hash functions, where the output of each hash function is a signature (316) for the data (308).

(29) Readers will appreciate that multiple signatures (316) for the data (308) may be generated not only by applying multiple hash functions to the same data (308), but multiple signatures (316) for the data (308) may also be generated by applying one or more hash functions to different portions of the data (308). Consider an example in which the data (308) includes 4 kilobytes ('KBs'). In such an example, a hash function may be applied to all 4 KBs to generate a first signature, a hash function may be applied to the first 512 bytes only to generate a second signature, a hash function may be applied to the last 512 bytes only to generate a third signature, a hash function may be applied to a middle 512 bytes only to generate a fourth signature, and so on. Readers will appreciate that the decision to apply multiple hash functions to data, to segment the data into a plurality of portions (which may or may not overlap), or any combination thereof are all design decisions that are well within the scope of the present disclosure.

(30) The example method depicted in FIG. 3 also includes determining (336) whether any of the calculated signatures (316) match a calculated signature (320, 322, 324, 326) contained in a recently read signature buffer (318). The recently read signature buffer (318) of FIG. 3 represents a data structure that associates a calculated signature (320, 322, 324, 326) for data that has been read with an address (328, 330, 332, 334) of a storage location within the storage device where the data is stored. As will be described in greater detail below, each time that a particular storage array controller reads data from a storage device (360, 362, 364), a deduplication module (310) executing on the storage array controller may calculate one or more signatures for the data read from a storage device (360, 362, 364) by applying the one or more predetermined hash functions referenced above to the data read from a storage device (360, 362, 364). Alternatively, in an embodiment where the storage device (360, 362, 364) calculates and stores one or more signatures for data stored by the storage devices (360, 362, 364), the deduplication module (310) executing on the storage array controller may retrieve the one or more signatures from the storage device (360, 362, 364) when the data is read from the storage device (360, 362, 364). Each of the one or more signatures for the data read from the storage device (360, 362, 364) may be stored in the recently read signature buffer (318) along with the address in the storage device (360, 362, 364) where the

data is stored.

(31) In the example method depicted in FIG. 3, determining (336) whether any of the calculated signatures (316) match a calculated signature (320, 322, 324, 326) contained in a recently read signature buffer (318) may be carried out, for example, by comparing the calculated signatures (316) for the data (308) associated with the write request (306) to each calculated signature (320, 322, 324, 326) contained in the recently read signature buffer (318). If the deduplication module (310) determines that the calculated signatures (316) for the data (308) associated with the write request (306) do not (342) match any of the a calculated signature (320, 322, 324, 326) contained in a recently read signature buffer (318), the deduplication module (310) can safely determine that the data (308) associated with the write request (306) is not a duplicate of any data that was recently read and whose signature was retained in the recently read signature buffer (318). If the deduplication module (310) determines that the calculated signatures (316) for the data (308) associated with the write request (306) does (338) match one or more of the calculated signatures (320, 322, 324, 326) contained in a recently read signature buffer (318), however, the deduplication module (310) can determine that the data (308) associated with the write request (306) may already be stored on the storage device (360, 362, 364).

(32) If the deduplication module (310) determines that the calculated signatures (316) for the data (308) associated with the write request (306) does (338) match one or more of the a calculated signatures (320, 322, 324, 326) contained in a recently read signature buffer (318), the deduplication module (310) can determine (340) whether the data (308) associated with the calculated signature (316) is a duplicate of data stored at a particular address (328, 330, 332, 334) that is associated with the calculated signature (320, 322, 324, 326) contained in the recently read signature buffer (318). Determining (340) whether the data (308) associated with the calculated signature (316) is a duplicate of data stored at a particular address (328, 330, 332, 334) that is associated with the calculated signature (320, 322, 324, 326) contained in the recently read signature buffer (318) may be carried out, for example, by obtaining the data that is stored at the particular address (328, 330, 332, 334) that is associated with the calculated signature (320, 322, 324, 326) contained in the recently read signature buffer (318) and performing a bit-by-bit comparison of the retrieved data to the data (308) associated with the calculated signature (316).

(33) Determining (340) whether the data (308) associated with the calculated signature (316) is a duplicate of data stored at a particular address (328, 330, 332, 334) that is associated with the calculated signature (320, 322, 324, 326) contained in the recently read signature buffer (318) can be carried out in response to affirmatively (338) determining that one of the calculated signatures (316) matches a calculated signature (320, 322, 324, 326) contained in the recently read signature buffer (318). Readers will appreciate that affirmatively (338) determining that one of the calculated signatures (316) matches a calculated signature (320, 322, 324, 326) contained in the recently read signature buffer (318) may only be indicative that the data (308) associated with the calculated signature (316) may be a duplicate of data stored at a particular address (328, 330, 332, 334) that is associated with the calculated signature (320, 322, 324, 326) contained in the recently read signature buffer (318). For example, if a particular hash function is used that is relatively weak, but relatively quick to perform, collisions may occur where distinct data results in the same hash value. As such, in order to definitively determine whether the data (308) associated with the calculated signature (316) is a duplicate of data stored at a particular address (328, 330, 332, 334) that is associated with the calculated signature (320, 322, 324, 326) contained in the recently read signature buffer (318), the data (308) associated with the calculated signature (316) and the data stored at a particular address (328, 330, 332, 334) that is associated with the calculated signature (320, 322, 324, 326) contained in the recently read signature buffer (318) must actually be compared.

(34) In response to affirmatively (344) determining that the data (308) associated with the write request (306) is a duplicate of data stored at a particular address (328, 330, 332, 334) that is

associated with the calculated signature (320, 322, 324, 326) contained in the recently read signature buffer (318), a reference (348) to the particular address (328, 330, 332, 334) is returned. The reference (348) to the particular address (328, 330, 332, 334) where data is stored that is a duplicate of the data (308) associated with the write request (306) may be embodied, for example, as a pointer to the particular address (328, 330, 332, 334) where data is stored that is a duplicate of the data (308) associated with the write request (306), as the particular address (328, 330, 332, 334) itself where data is stored that is a duplicate of the data (308) associated with the write request (306), and so on. In the example method depicted in FIG. 3, returning a reference (348) to the particular address (328, 330, 332, 334) can include storing the reference (348) to the particular address (328, 330, 332, 334) at a memory location where the data (308) associated with the write request (306) would have been stored, if not for the fact that a duplicate copy of the data (308) associated with the write request (306) was already stored in the storage device (360, 362, 364).

(35) In response to determining that the data (308) associated with the write request (306) is not (350) a duplicate of data stored at a particular address (328, 330, 332, 334) that is associated with the calculated signature (320, 322, 324, 326) contained in the recently read signature buffer (318), the write request (306) is forwarded (352) to the storage device (360, 362, 364). The write request (306) may be forwarded (352) to the storage device (360, 362, 364) so that the storage device (360, 362, 364) can service the write request (306). Readers will appreciate that forwarding (352) the write request (306) to the storage device (360, 362, 364) does not necessarily result in the data (308) associated with the write request (306) being written to the storage device (360, 362, 364). The data (308) associated with the write request (306) may not ultimately be written to the storage device (360, 362, 364) because a controller or other form of computer logic may determine that some data, already stored in the storage device (360, 362, 364) but not reflected in the recently read signature buffer (318), matches the data (308) associated with the write request (306). Readers will further appreciate that the data (308) associated with the write request (306) may undergo further processing prior to forwarding (352) the write request (306) to the storage device (360, 362, 364). For example, the data (308) associated with the write request (306) may be compressed, encrypted, or otherwise processed according to various design decisions that are each within the scope of the present disclosure.

(36) Although the example described above makes reference to preventing duplicate entries of identical data in a storage device (360, 362, 364), readers will appreciate that the steps described above can be applied to a single storage device and also applied to multiple storage devices, such as all of the storage devices (360, 362, 364) in the storage device array (358). Preventing duplicate entries of identical data across all storage devices (360, 362, 364) in the storage device array (358) may be carried out, for example, through the use of an addressing scheme where the addresses in each storage device (360, 362, 364) are unique, by associating a device identifier with the addresses (328, 330, 332, 334) stored in the recently read signature buffer (318) if the addresses in each storage device are not unique, and so on. Because the deduplication module (310) may reside on a storage array controller that facilitates accesses to all storage devices (360, 362, 364) in the storage device array (358), the deduplication module (310) may be configured to maintain a recently read signature buffer (318) that includes information describing data read from all storage devices (360, 362, 364) in the storage device array (358). In the event that redundant storage array controllers facilitate accesses to all storage devices (360, 362, 364) in the storage device array (358), the storage array controllers may be configured to communicate with each other to maintain a recently read signature buffer (318) that includes information describing data read from all storage devices (360, 362, 364) in the storage device array (358).

(37) For further explanation, FIG. 4 sets forth a flow chart illustrating an example method for preventing duplicate entries of identical data in a storage device according to embodiments of the present invention. The example method depicted in FIG. 4 is similar to the example method depicted in FIG. 3, as the example method depicted in FIG. 4 also includes receiving (312) a write

request (306) to write data (308) to one or more of the storage devices (360, 362, 364) in an array (358) of storage devices, calculating (314) one or more signatures (316) for the data (308) associated with the write request (306), determining (336) whether any of the calculated signatures (316) match a calculated signature (408) contained in a recently read signature buffer (318), and determining (340) whether the data (308) associated with the calculated signature (316) is a duplicate of data stored at a particular address (422) that is associated with the calculated signature (408) contained in the recently read signature buffer (318).

(38) The example method depicted in FIG. 4 also includes retrieving (404) stored data (402). The stored data (402) may be retrieved (404), for example, from one of the storage devices (360, 362, 364) in the array (358) of storage devices in response to a read request received by a storage array controller. Such a read request may include an identifier of the stored data (402) such as a file name, an address for the stored data (402), information identifying the user, computer, other entity, or logical, virtual, or physical storage device that issued the read request, or any other information needed to service the read request.

(39) The example method depicted in FIG. 4 also includes obtaining (406) a calculated signature (408) for the stored data (402). Obtaining (406) a calculated signature (408) for the stored data (402) may be carried out, for example, by applying a predetermined hash function to the stored data (402). In such a way, the deduplication module (310) may calculate the signature (408) for the stored data (402). In an alternative embodiment, the signature (408) may be calculated by a storage array controller, by processing logic on one of the storage devices (360, 362, 364), or by some other entity, and stored in the storage device (360, 362, 364) along with the stored data (402) itself. In such an alternative embodiment, the calculated signature (408) for the stored data (402) may be obtained (406) by retrieving the calculated signature (408) for the stored data (402) from one of the storage devices (360, 362, 364) as part of retrieving (404) the stored data (402), and so on.

(40) The example method depicted in FIG. 4 also includes storing (410), in the recently read signature buffer (318), the calculated signature (408) for the stored data (402) and an address (422) of a storage location on the storage device (360, 362, 364) where the stored data (402) resides. Storing (410) the calculated signature (408) for the stored data (402) and an address (422) of a storage location on the storage device (360, 362, 364) where the stored data (402) resides may be carried out, for example, by: removing an entry from the recently read signature buffer (318) and replacing the removed entry with the calculated signature (408) for the stored data (402) and the address (422) for the stored data (402); identifying an empty or outdated entry in the recently read signature buffer (318) and replacing the empty or outdated entry with the calculated signature (408) for the stored data (402) and the address (422) for the stored data (402); and in other ways as will occur to readers of skill in the art. Readers will appreciate that each time that stored data (402) is read from one of the storage devices (360, 362, 364), the calculated signature (408) and the address (422) for the stored data (402) may be stored (410) in the recently read signature buffer (318) such that entries in the recently read signature buffer (318) remain current. Readers will further appreciate the calculated signature (408) and the address (422) for the stored data (402) may be stored (410) in the recently read signature buffer (318) for only a subset of the times that stored data (402) is read from one of the storage devices (360, 362, 364) in accordance with embodiments described herein.

(41) In the example method depicted in FIG. 4, storing (410) the calculated signature (408) for the stored data (402) and the address (422) of the stored data (402) in the recently read signature buffer (318) can include determining (412) whether the calculated signature (408) for the stored data (402) matches a calculated signature in an entry of the recently read signature buffer (318). In order to avoid creating duplicate entries in the recently read signature buffer (318), the deduplication module (310) may determine (412) whether the calculated signature (408) for the stored data (402) matches a calculated signature in an entry of the recently read signature buffer (318).

(42) In response to affirmatively (414) determining that the calculated signature (408) for the stored

data (402) matches calculated signature in an entry of the recently read signature buffer (318), the entry in the recently read signature buffer (318) may be refreshed (416). Refreshing (416) the entry in the recently read signature buffer (318) that matches the calculated signature (408) for the stored data (402) may be carried out, for example, by updating a timestamp identifying the time at which the stored data (402) was retrieved (404) in response to a read request. In an alternative embodiment where the recently read signature buffer (318) is sorted, for example, such that older entries appear at the front of the recently read signature buffer (318) and newer entries appear at the back recently read signature buffer (318), refreshing (416) the entry in the recently read signature buffer (318) that matches the calculated signature (408) for the stored data (402) may be carried out by moving the entry to a location within the recently read signature buffer (318) that is designated for newer entries. Readers will appreciate that the recently read signature buffer (318) may be organized in other ways and that refreshing (416) the entry in the recently read signature buffer (318) that matches the calculated signature (408) for the stored data (402) may be carried in accordance with any corresponding organization policy. Furthermore, refreshing (416) the entry in the recently read signature buffer (318) that matches the calculated signature (408) for the stored data (402) might only be carried out for a subset of situations in which the calculated signature (408) for the stored data (402) is affirmatively (414) determined to match a calculated signature in an entry of the recently read signature buffer (318), as retaining the original signature may be preferable in certain circumstances.

(43) For further explanation, FIG. 5 sets forth a flow chart illustrating an example method for preventing duplicate entries of identical data in a storage device according to embodiments of the present invention. The example method depicted in FIG. 5 is similar to the example method depicted in FIG. 3, as the example method depicted in FIG. 5 also includes receiving (312) a write request (306) to write data (308) to one or more of the storage devices (360, 362, 364) in an array (358) of storage devices, calculating (314) one or more signatures (316) for the data (308) associated with the write request (306), determining (336) whether any of the calculated signatures (316) match a calculated signature (320, 322, 324, 326) contained in a recently read signature buffer (318), and determining (340) whether the data (308) associated with the calculated signature (316) is a duplicate of data stored at a particular address (328, 330, 332, 334) that is associated with the calculated signature (320, 322, 324, 326) contained in the recently read signature buffer (318).

(44) In the example method depicted in FIG. 5, determining (340) whether the data (308) associated with the calculated signature (316) is a duplicate of data stored at a particular address (328, 330, 332, 334) that is associated with the calculated signature (320, 322, 324, 326) contained in the recently read signature buffer (318) can include obtaining (502) the data (504) stored at the particular address (328, 330, 332, 334). Obtaining (502) the data (504) stored at the particular address (328, 330, 332, 334) may be carried out, for example, by reading the data (504) from the storage device (360, 362, 364) using the particular address (328, 330, 332, 334). In an alternative embodiment, a cache may exist to temporarily store data that is read from one of the storage devices and associated with an entry in the recently read signature buffer (318). For example, the first entry in the recently read signature buffer (318) of FIG. 1 includes a signature (320) for recently read data and the address (328) at which the recently read data is stored. In such an example, the recently read data itself may be stored in the cache, such that obtaining (502) the data (504) stored at the particular address (328) may be carried out by retrieving the data (504) from the cache.

(45) In the example method depicted in FIG. 5, determining (340) whether the data (308) associated with the calculated signature (316) is a duplicate of data stored at a particular address (328, 330, 332, 334) that is associated with the calculated signature (320, 322, 324, 326) contained in the recently read signature buffer (318) can also include comparing (506) the data (504) stored at the particular address (328, 330, 332, 334) to the data (308) associated with the write request (306). By performing an actual comparison (506) of the data (504) stored at the particular address (328,

330, 332, 334) to the data (308) associated with the write request (306), a definitive determination can be made as to whether the data (504) stored at the particular address (328, 330, 332, 334) and the data (308) associated with the write request (306) are duplicates. Readers will appreciate that the mere fact that the signature for the data (504) stored at the particular address (328, 330, 332, 334) matches the signature for the data (308) associated with the write request (306), does not necessarily mean that the data (504) stored at the particular address (328, 330, 332, 334) is a duplicate of the data (308) associated with the write request (306). That is, matching signatures may occasionally be generated from dissimilar data as some hash functions may occasionally result in collisions. The strength of a hash function may be increased to reduce or eliminate such collisions, but a design decision may be made to utilize a weaker hash function which requires less time and computing resources to apply. Furthermore, a weaker hash function may also result in a smaller hash value, thereby requiring less space to store and enabling more signatures to be stored in a given space, relative to a stronger hash function. With all hash functions, however, applying the same hash function to identical data will produce the same signatures.

(46) For further explanation, FIG. 6 sets forth a flow chart illustrating an example method for preventing duplicate entries of identical data in a storage device according to embodiments of the present invention. The example method depicted in FIG. 6 is similar to the example method depicted in FIG. 3, as the example method depicted in FIG. 6 also includes receiving (312) a write request (306) to write data (308) to one or more of the storage devices (360, 362, 364) in an array (358) of storage devices, calculating (314) one or more signatures (316) for the data (308) associated with the write request (306), determining (336) whether any of the calculated signatures (316) match a calculated signature (320) contained in a recently read signature buffer (318), and determining (340) whether the data (308) associated with the calculated signature (316) is a duplicate of data stored at a particular address (328) that is associated with the calculated signature (320) contained in the recently read signature buffer (318).

(47) The example method depicted in FIG. 6 also includes identifying (602), in dependence upon predetermined removal rules, one or more entries to remove from the recently read signature buffer (318). The predetermined removal rules may specify a removal policy for the recently read signature buffer (318) such as a policy to remove an entry in the recently read signature buffer (318) that is associated with the least recently read data, or a policy to remove an entry in the recently read signature buffer (318) that includes an address (328) that has been written to since being added to the recently read signature buffer (318), and so on. Readers will appreciate that predetermined removal rules may specify other removal policies and that identifying (602) one or more entries to remove from the recently read signature buffer (318) in accordance with such predetermined removal rules.

(48) The example method depicted in FIG. 6 also includes removing (604) the one or more entries from the recently read signature buffer (318). Removing (604) the one or more entries from the recently read signature buffer (318) may be carried out, for example, by deleting the one or more entries from the recently read signature buffer (318), by overwriting the one or more entries from the recently read signature buffer (318) to include new entries, and so on.

(49) In the example method depicted in FIG. 6, determining (340) whether the data (308) associated with the calculated signature (316) is a duplicate of data stored at a particular address (328) that is associated with the calculated signature (320) contained in the recently read signature buffer (318) can include comparing (606) the data associated with the calculated signature to data stored in a cache that is associated with information contained in the recently read signature buffer (318). The cache may be embodied, for example, as a general purpose cache that temporarily stores data that is read from one of the storage devices and associated with an entry in the recently read signature buffer (318). In such an example, the recently read data itself may be stored in the cache, such that obtaining the data stored at the particular address (328) included in the recently read signature buffer (318) may be carried out by retrieving the data from the cache.

(50) The example method depicted in FIG. 6 illustrates an embodiment where identifying (602) one or more entries to remove from the recently read signature buffer (318) and removing (604) the one or more entries from the recently read signature buffer (318) are included as part of a larger process that includes receiving (312) a write request (306), determining (336) whether any of the calculated signatures (316) match a calculated signature (320) contained in a recently read signature buffer (318), and determining (340) whether the data (308) associated with the calculated signature (316) is a duplicate of data stored at a particular address (328) that is associated with the calculated signature (320) contained in the recently read signature buffer (318). Readers will appreciate, however, that identifying (602) one or more entries to remove from the recently read signature buffer (318) and removing (604) the one or more entries from the recently read signature buffer (318) may be carried out as isolated steps whose occurrence is not contingent upon the occurrence of the remaining steps depicted in FIG. 6. In other words, entries may be removed from the recently read signature buffer (318) as part of an independent process, without immediately or even eventually receiving (312) a write request (306) and performing the remaining steps depicted in FIG. 6.

(51) Example embodiments of the present invention are described largely in the context of a fully functional computer system. Readers of skill in the art will recognize, however, that the present invention also may be embodied in a computer program product disposed upon computer readable media for use with any suitable data processing system. Such computer readable storage media may be any transitory or non-transitory media. Examples of such media include storage media for machine-readable information, including magnetic media, optical media, or other suitable media. Examples of such media also include magnetic disks in hard drives or diskettes, compact disks for optical drives, magnetic tape, and others as will occur to those of skill in the art. Persons skilled in the art will immediately recognize that any computer system having suitable programming means will be capable of executing the steps of the method of the invention as embodied in a computer program product. Persons skilled in the art will recognize also that, although some of the example embodiments described in this specification are oriented to software installed and executing on computer hardware, nevertheless, alternative embodiments implemented as firmware, as hardware, or as an aggregation of hardware and software are well within the scope of embodiments of the present invention.

(52) It will be understood from the foregoing description that modifications and changes may be made in various embodiments of the present invention without departing from its true spirit. The descriptions in this specification are for purposes of illustration only and are not to be construed in a limiting sense. The scope of the present invention is limited only by the language of the following claims.

Claims

1. A method comprising: determining, by a processing device, whether a calculated signature for write data matches a particular signature corresponding to data that was recently read from the storage device, wherein the calculated signature is calculated using the write data as input; and after determining that the calculated signature for the write data matches the particular signature, obtaining the data that was recently read and comparing the data that was recently read to the write data to identify duplicate data within the write data.
2. The method of claim 1 further comprising: retrieving the data from one or more storage devices; obtaining a signature for the data; and storing, in the signature buffer, the signature for the data and an address of a storage location where the data resides.
3. The method of claim 2 wherein storing the signature for the data and an address of a storage location where the data resides includes: determining whether the signature for the data matches a signature in an entry of the signature buffer; and responsive to determining that the signature for

the data matches the signature in the entry of the signature buffer, refreshing the entry in the signature buffer.

4. The method of claim 1 further comprising: identifying, in dependence upon predetermined removal rules, one or more entries to remove from the signature buffer; and removing the one or more entries from the signature buffer.

5. The method of claim 1 wherein determining whether the write data is a duplicate of the data stored at the address associated with the particular signature further comprises: obtaining the data stored at the address; and comparing the data stored at the address to the write data.

6. The method of claim 5 further comprising, responsive to determining that the write data is the duplicate of the data stored at the address, returning a reference to the address.

7. The method of claim 1 wherein determining whether the write data is a duplicate of the data stored at the address associated with the particular signature further comprises comparing the write data to data stored in a cache that is associated with information contained in the signature buffer.

8. An apparatus comprising: a memory; and a processing device, operatively coupled with the memory, the processing device configured to: determine whether a calculated signature for write data matches a particular signature corresponding to data that was recently read from the storage device, wherein the calculated signature is calculated using the write data as input; and after determining that the calculated signature for the write data matches the particular signature, obtain the data that was recently read and compare the data that was recently read to the write data to identify duplicate data within the write data.

9. The apparatus of claim 8 wherein the processing device is further configured to: retrieve the data from one or more storage devices; obtain a signature for the data; and store, in the signature buffer, the signature for the data and an address of a storage location where the data resides.

10. The apparatus of claim 9 wherein to store storing the signature for the data and an address of a storage location where the data resides, the processing device is further configured to: determine whether the signature for the data matches a signature in an entry of the signature buffer; and responsive to determining that the signature for the data matches the signature in the entry of the signature buffer, refresh the entry in the signature buffer.

11. The apparatus of claim 8 wherein the processing device is further configured to: identify, in dependence upon predetermined removal rules, one or more entries to remove from the signature buffer; and remove the one or more entries from the signature buffer.

12. The apparatus of claim 8 wherein to determine whether the write data is a duplicate of the data stored at the address associated with the particular signature the processing device is further configured to: obtain the data stored at the address; and compare the data stored at the address to the write data.

13. The apparatus of claim 8, wherein the processing device is further configured to: responsive to determining that the write data is the duplicate of the data stored at the address, return a reference to the address.

14. The apparatus of claim 8 wherein to determine whether the write data is a duplicate of the data stored at the address associated with the particular signature further comprises the processing device is further configured to: compare the write data to data stored in a cache that is associated with information contained in the signature buffer.

15. A non-transitory computer readable storage medium storing instructions that, when executed by a processing device, cause the processing device to: determine, by the processing device, whether a calculated signature for write data matches a particular signature corresponding to data that was recently read from the storage device, wherein the calculated signature is calculated using the write data as input; and after determining that the calculated signature for the write data matches the particular signature, obtain the data that was recently read and compare the data that was recently read to the write data to identify duplicate data within the write data.

16. The non-transitory computer readable storage medium of claim 15, wherein the processing

device is further to: retrieve the data from one or more storage devices; obtain a signature for the data; and store, in the signature buffer, the signature for the data and an address of a storage location where the data resides.

17. The non-transitory computer readable storage medium of claim 16 wherein to store the signature for the data and an address of a storage location where the data resides the processing device is further to: determine whether the signature for the data matches a signature in an entry of the signature buffer; and responsive to determining that the signature for the data matches the signature in the entry of the signature buffer, refresh the entry in the signature buffer.

18. The non-transitory computer readable storage medium of claim 15, wherein the processing device is further to: identify, in dependence upon predetermined removal rules, one or more entries to remove from the signature buffer; and remove the one or more entries from the signature buffer.

19. The non-transitory computer readable storage medium of claim 15 wherein to determine whether the write data is a duplicate of the data stored at the address associated with the particular signature the processing device is further to: obtain the data stored at the address; and compare the data stored at the address to the write data.

20. The non-transitory computer readable storage medium of claim 15 wherein to determine whether the write data is a duplicate of the data stored at the address associated with the particular signature the processing device is further to: compare the write data to data stored in a cache that is associated with information contained in the signature buffer.
